Magic rule – Saving throw spells (areas, spheres, cones) · SRD 5.2.1

A **saving throw** spell has no attack roll: each target makes a **saving throw** against the caster's **spell save DC**. The **area** (sphere, cone, cube...) determines who is affected; cover helps **Dexterity** saves.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Spell save DC: **8 + mod. + proficiency**.
2. Each creature in the area makes **its own save**.
3. Success: often **half damage**.
4. No attack roll: **no critical hit**.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 keeps the spell save DC and states the effect of a successful save in each spell's description.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say whether the caster can spare allies. Fix: only a spell that says so allows it; otherwise everyone in the area is affected.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the area with visible landmarks (rocks, walls) to know who is inside.

Step 1 – Choose the point:

Designate the area's origin within the spell's range.

Step 2 – List targets:

Every creature in the area and in line of effect is concerned.

Step 3 – Save:

Each target rolls 1d20 + save modifier against the DC.

Step 4 – Cover:

Half cover: **+2** to Dex saves; three-quarters cover: **+5**.

Step 5 – Effect:

Failure: full effect. Success: half damage or no effect, per the spell.

Example: Ysolde casts Fireball (DC 15). A goblin behind a pillar (+2) rolls 14+2: it succeeds and takes half damage.

Situation	Effect on the save
No cover	No bonus
Half cover (furniture, creature)	+2 to Dexterity saves
Three-quarters cover (arrow slit, trunk)	+5 to Dexterity saves
Total cover	Can’t be targeted
Evasion (Rogue, Monk)	Successful Dex save: no damage

⚠ Common questions:

Is there an attack roll?

No, only saves.

What DC?

8 + ability mod. + proficiency.

Does the area spare allies?

Only if the spell says so.

Can it crit?

No, there is no attack roll.

What does cover do?

+2 or +5 on Dex saves.

Who makes the save?

Each creature in the area.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Allies in the area

Can I spare them? **Option**: no, unless stated.

Crit on save

Does a natural 20 change anything? **Option**: no.

Choosing targets

Can I pick just one? **Option**: no for areas.

Cone in a corridor

Does a cone fit? **Option**: yes, it narrows.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

No attack

Saving throw spells never crit.

Cover

It helps Dexterity, not other saves.

Areas of effect

See the Areas of Effect and Lines of Sight sheet.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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